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(NHA), the implementing agency of Ayushman Bharat, should consider allowing co-payments. This would enable beneficiaries to seek treatment from specialist hospitals for serious ailments,” says Gyani. He also recommends standardising the empanelment process across states and issuing smart cards for interoperability.

To make PM-JAY more effective in smaller towns, Gyani proposes

incentivising the private sector to establish 100-bed tertiary care hospitals in Tier-III towns.

Per the latest data on the PM-JAY website, over 340 million Ayushman cards have been issued, and about 68 million hospital admissions worth ₹90,204 crore have been authorised through a network of 30,001 empanelled healthcare providers, including 12,971 private hospitals.

In states or UTs where AB-PM-

JAY has not been implemented, the NHA has directly empanelled hospitals to ensure beneficiaries can still access healthcare facilities. Beneficiaries of state schemes merged with AB-PM-JAY can also use healthcare services in any empanelled hospital nationwide under the portability feature of the scheme. The scheme also focuses on strengthening primary health centres. At Ayushman Bharat Health and Wellness Centres, comprehensive healthcare services are provided free of cost, covering maternal and child health, non-communicable diseases, essential drugs, and diagnostic services.

In its manifesto for the General Elections, the BJP pledged to further expand the scheme to include senior citizens and transgender persons. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has promised to strengthen the health and wellness centres, upgrading district hospitals, and enhancing secondary care centres. The ongoing efforts under the PM-Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission aim to build a robust infrastructure, especially at the primary level, the manifesto stated.

“The government faces high expectations in the healthcare sector, with a multifaceted agenda aimed at improving access, affordability, and quality of care,” says Sabine Kapasi, Advisor, Public Health and Healthcare Services Strategist at the United Nations. She stresses the importance of broader financial protection, adopting a ‘One Health’ approach, and strengthening public-private partnerships.

Kapasi says the new government should prioritise ensuring cash inflow into insurance infrastructure, subsidising insurance costs for higher penetration, standardising health treatment prices to prevent exploitation, and achieving full saturation and adoption of the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission. **BT**

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